The Personal Preferences Checklist

What to ask Dad, write down and confirm with him about his ordinary day.

Dad is well, and nobody is talking about caregivers. You've simply noticed how much of his day you know by guesswork. Take these one conversation at a time, in any order, with no date to finish by. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something you haven't asked him yet, and that is all it is.

Ask

- [ ] Ask Dad to describe a good day, start to finish, and let him tell it his own way. [1]
- [ ] Ask about his usual routines: how the morning starts and how the evening winds down.
- [ ] Ask what he enjoys eating, what he'd rather not have, and when he usually has his meals.
- [ ] Ask which activities and which people he looks forward to.
- [ ] Ask how he likes to be spoken to, and what he likes to be called.
- [ ] Ask what helps when he's somewhere unfamiliar.

Write down

- [ ] His answers, in his own words where you caught them, each with the date and who heard it.
- [ ] The things the family believes about his preferences that nobody has actually asked him.
- [ ] Allergies and anything a doctor has told him about food, on a separate list from what he likes and dislikes. Note where each one came from. If nobody is sure, write “not sure” and leave it for his doctor or pharmacist.
- [ ] Anything he says has changed over the years, in his words.

Confirm

- [ ] Read the page back to him, and change what he wants changed.
- [ ] Ask what he's happy to have shared, and with whom.
- [ ] Ask which few things he'd want on a short version, if one were ever shared with people helping him.
- [ ] Agree to ask again later, so that nobody treats the page as permanent. [1]

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you ask, note and check back. It doesn't tell you what Dad would want in a situation he hasn't talked about, and it doesn't turn anything he likes into an instruction for someone else to follow. A page with every box checked is still a set of notes. What they add up to is for the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked Dad, written down what he said and checked it back with him. The care interview sets those notes beside the rest of his situation, area by area, so his preferences aren't kept on a page of their own, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow The Conversation Project's workbook, which asks what a good day looks like and suggests coming back to the answers over time. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care